BOOKS

Between the Notes

In *A Lost People's Archive*, Rimli Sengupta combines imagination and history to tell a very personal tale of the Partition of Bengal



A LOST PEOPLE'S ARCHIVE
A Novel
by Rimli Sengupta
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹699; 232 pages

I can attest that historical fiction is one of the hardest genres to write. You have to research your subject like a career scholar, and then render down all these unwieldy lumps of fact into a smooth, tasty fictional broth that goes down easy. You don't have footnotes to back you up, which means you can't explain yourself. You walk this tightrope carefully, knowing that on one side you risk a tumble on the hard rocks of geeking out on your material, and on the other you are menaced by the tar pits of pandering to popular taste.

Rimli Sengupta, who is not a career historian, nevertheless pulls off a brilliant balancing act of a book that gives you all the feel of a novel while staying true to its material. I say she's not a historian only because the rules of academia will cause my colleagues to harrumph collectively if I say she is one. But any career historian would be proud to have written this, and I would go so far as to say that Sengupta does a better job because she's not bound by the shibboleths of academic training. This book is deeply-felt history, written with thoroughness, fearlessness and respect. Despite the personal nature of the source material, it is a story that speaks for all of Bengal.

SENGUPTA'S SOURCE IS A NOTEBOOK OF POEMS LEFT TO HER GRANDMOTHER BY HER LIFELONG FRIEND, THE POET AND REVOLUTIONARY RAMESH CHATTERJI (SHISHU)

Sengupta's source is a notebook of poems left to her grandmother by her lifelong friend, the poet and revolutionary Ramesh Chatterji (Shishu). Through it she rediscovers their lives and times. Or rather, she is haunted by them in a manner that will be familiar to all historians. That vertiginous experience when the people you are studying become living presences in your head: opinionated, talkative, more real than the world your body lives in. They sucker you into writing '1895' on checks and laugh when people give you funny looks. Such is the fate of the writer.

Shishu's imagined spirit becomes Sengupta's writing partner, commenting on his own life with ghostly glosses sharpened by hindsight. He leads her through the harrowing exploration of the aftermath of his single blow for Indian Independence, struck when he was a mere child, and his subsequent long years of incarceration, with poetry his only rebellion. We follow him through his harshest years, at Alipore Jail, then the Cellular Jail in the Andamans, and back to Alipore where he witnesses the Famine from behind bars. All of this is compost for his poetry, the one act of defiance still left to him in the jails of the coloniser.

But the aftermath of Independence brings no succour. While the western Partition was violent and shortlived, the Partition of Bengal lingered on in a thousand cuts, and its agonies still plague the Bengal ethos like a phantom limb. Even after surviving jail, Shishu must come to terms with multiple betrayals. Only Noni's allyship remains true. This book is pitch-perfect in its singing of the river songs. ■

–Rimi B. Chatterjee